

His Feet Like Burnished Bronze

The Story Hiding Inside Four Words

There is a description of Jesus in the first chapter of Revelation that most readers pass over in a second or two. John, exiled on the island of Patmos, turns to see who is speaking to him and finds himself facing the risen Christ. He describes what he sees piece by piece: hair white like wool, eyes like a flame of fire, and then this: "His feet were like burnished bronze, refined in a furnace."

I have heard many people explain that verse in shallow ways. Some say it means Jesus was bronze colored. Others say the burnished bronze glowing in the fire means he appeared white. But Scripture is almost never shallow. It works in layers, and the deepest layers live in the original words themselves, in Hebrew and Greek, in roots and sounds and even in the numbers the Hebrew letters carry. When you slow down and read the actual words, this single image of glowing feet turns out to be the final knot in a thread that runs through the entire Bible, from the Garden of Eden to the throne room of heaven. It is a story told in four words, and if you do not pay attention to the words, you will miss all of it.

So let me tell the whole story, from the very beginning.

The Garden: A Word That Shines

The story starts in Genesis 3, with the creature that deceives humanity. In English we call it "the serpent," and most of us picture a snake in the grass. But the Hebrew word is נָחָשׁ, *nachash*, and that word is doing far more work than our translations let on.

The root n-ch-sh carries three meanings braided together. As a noun, it is the serpent. As a related word, it is bronze, the gleaming metal. And as a verb, it means to shine, to gleam like bright metal, and also to practice divination, to whisper omens. When an ancient Hebrew reader saw the word *nachash*, they did not merely picture a garden snake. They pictured a glistening, shining, bronze-colored entity, a radiant thing that whispers. This is why many biblical scholars note that Eve was not talking to a dirty animal in the dust. She was talking to a shining one, a radiant heavenly being in rebellion against God. That entity used its deceptive radiance to bring the poison of sin and death into the human story.

Hold on to that word. Serpent, bronze, shining. The whole Bible is about to play it like an instrument.

The Burning Bush: The Sign in the Staff

Centuries pass. Israel is enslaved in Egypt, and God meets Moses at the burning bush. Notice what God does there. He does not yet ask Moses to make anything out of metal. Instead he gives Moses a sign of power: throw your shepherd's staff on the ground. Moses does, and the staff instantly becomes a living snake, a *nachash*, and Moses flees from it in terror.

Think about what that sign means. The shepherd's ordinary tool becomes the very image of the enemy from Eden, and then, at God's command, Moses grasps it by the tail and it becomes a staff again, now the staff of God, the instrument that will split the sea. The shining serpent, the emblem of the curse, is seized and mastered in Moses' own hand. It is a preview. God is telling Moses, and us, that the serpent's power is not the last word. The last word belongs to the One who can take hold of it.

The Wilderness: The Wound and the Cure Welded Into One Name

The full weight of that preview lands in the wilderness, in Numbers 21. Israel rebels against God on the journey, and venomous snakes come among the people. Men and women are bitten and dying. And then God gives Moses one of the strangest commands in all of Scripture: make a replica of the very thing killing them, lift it up on a pole, and anyone who looks at it will live.

Here is where the words start to sing.

The metal God specifies is נְּשִׁיחַ, *nechosheth*, bronze. Bronze was not chosen at random. It sounds almost identical to the word for snake. When Moses makes the bronze serpent, the Hebrew text reads *nachash nechosheth*, a literal phonetic rhyme, the serpent of serpent-metal, the shining thing cast in shining metal. And in biblical symbolism bronze is the metal of judgment by fire, because metal is refined in the furnace. The altar in the Tabernacle, the place where sin was dealt with by fire, was made of bronze. So when Moses casts the serpent in bronze, he is visually showing the people the shining serpent bound, fixed in metal, judged in the furnace. To be healed, the dying had to look directly at the emblem of their own curse being executed.

Centuries later, when Israel had turned Moses' bronze pole into an idol and burned incense to it, King Hezekiah smashed it and mocked it with a name that fused the two words into one: Nehushtan, a pun on both "serpent" and "a cheap piece of brass." Even the destruction of the object preserved the wordplay.

But the wordplay in Numbers 21 goes deeper still, and this is the part almost everyone

misses.

The Word Everyone Misses: Saraph

Read the passage closely and you find that the serpents are not only called *nachash*. The text calls them *ha-nechashim ha-seraphim*, the burning serpents, the fiery ones. The word is שָׂרָפִי, *saraph*, from a root that literally means to burn, to consume with fire. In the desert it names a venomous creature whose bite leaves scalding, burning venom in the blood of dying men.

And then, in verse 8, when God tells Moses what to forge, something remarkable happens. God drops the word *nachash* entirely. The plain Hebrew says: "Make yourself a saraph." Make a burning one.

Now trace that word forward. In Isaiah 6, the prophet is caught up into the throne room of God, and standing over the throne are the Seraphim, the multi-winged, majestic celestial beings, literally "the Burning Ones." It is the same word. The burning thing that bites in the desert and the burning thing that stands over the throne of God are, in the letters, one word.

And watch what a saraph does in Isaiah's vision. One of them flies to the altar, takes a white-hot burning coal of sacrifice, touches it to the prophet's unclean lips, and says: "Your guilt is taken away and your sin atoned for."

The theological inversion is breathtaking. In the wilderness, a saraph brings the burning fire of judgment and death. In the throne room, a saraph carries the burning fire of purification and atonement. When Moses casts the saraph in bronze, he is fusing the burning bite of judgment and the burning coal of atonement into a single physical object. The wound and the cure are welded into a single name.

The Second Word Everyone Misses: Nabat

There is one more word in the wilderness account, and it changes how you read the entire Bible.

God's initial command to Moses uses the ordinary Hebrew verb for sight, *ra'ah*: whoever is bitten, when he sees it, shall live. But when the healing actually happens, in Numbers 21:9, the text deliberately switches verbs: "if a serpent had bitten any man, when he beheld the serpent of bronze, he lived." The word there is נָבַט, *nabat*, and it is not a casual glance or catching something out of the corner of your eye. It is an intense, concentrated, expectant gaze, and its near relative as a noun carries the sense of expectation itself. You do not merely catch sight of the bronze serpent. You wait on it with your eyes. It is the look of someone fixing their gaze on a savior with absolute dependence.

Now follow that exact verb centuries down the canon, into the mouth of God through the prophet Zechariah, in one of the great prophetic climaxes of the Old Testament:

"And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem the Spirit of grace and supplication, and they shall look upon Me whom they have pierced, and they shall mourn for Him." (Zechariah 12:10)

The verb is *nabat*. The expectant gaze that healed a dying man in the wilderness is the same Hebrew act of seeing as Israel's gaze upon the pierced One. "Look and live" in the desert and "look on the pierced One and be saved" are the same word for the same kind of looking.

So stand back and take in what the wilderness account has done. The cure was a burning one cast in bronze, and the healing was an act of expectant looking, and both words were already reaching past the desert. One points up, to a throne where a burning one carries the coal that takes sin away. The other points forward, to a hill where they would gaze on the One they pierced. The wilderness was speaking the whole grammar of the cross before the cross had a name, in two small words nobody thought to read twice.

Jesus himself confirmed that this is exactly how to read it. In John 3:14, in the same conversation that gives us the most famous verse in the Bible, he said: "And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, even so must the Son of Man be lifted up." He took the curse of the bronze serpent upon himself so that the power of the ancient serpent would be broken.

The Prophets See the Bronze

Before we reach Revelation, two more prophets need to enter the story, because John will lean on both of them.

In Daniel 10:6, Daniel sees a vision of a heavenly man by the Tigris River, and he describes his arms and feet with the Hebrew phrase *nechosheth qalal*, polished or burnished bronze. When the Jewish scribes translated Daniel into the Greek Septuagint, they rendered it *hosis chalkou stilbontos*, "like the gleam of flashing, shining bronze."

In Ezekiel 1:7, Ezekiel sees the fiery cherubim who accompany the glory of God and notes that their legs were straight and their feet sparkled like burnished bronze, the same Hebrew phrase, *nechosheth qalal*. The Septuagint translated it *spintheres hosis exastrapton chalkos*, "sparkling like flashing, lightning-like bronze."

So by the time of the New Testament, "burnished bronze feet" was already the established signature of a divine being standing in the presence of God. Any Jewish reader steeped in the prophets would recognize it instantly.

Patmos: The Word John Had to Invent

Now, at last, we return to John on Patmos, staring at the glorified Christ.

The New Testament is written in Koine Greek, and to describe the metal of Christ's feet, John deploys a word found nowhere else in all of ancient Greek literature: χαλκολίβανον, *chalkolibanon*. It is a hapax legomenon, a word occurring only once, and its precise composition has fascinated linguists for centuries. It fuses *chalkos*, bronze or copper, with *libanos*, the Greek word for frankincense, which stems from an ancient Semitic root meaning "whiteness." The image is a brilliant, glowing alloy, or metal heated in a furnace to such an extreme temperature that it turns incandescent, white-hot.

Why would anyone weld bronze to frankincense? Because John needed a word that did not exist. He needed the exact linguistic bridge to carry the Hebrew wordplay of the wilderness into Greek, and he built it.

Consider what frankincense meant to anyone who knew the Temple. Frankincense was not perfume. It was a holy ingredient reserved exclusively for the altar. To make atonement, the priest would take a burning coal from the altar, place frankincense upon it, and a thick cloud of white smoke would rise and fill the Holy of Holies, covering the mercy seat. The Hebrew word for frankincense, *levonah*, like its Greek counterpart *libanos*, comes from that root meaning "white." When frankincense meets fire, it does not simply melt away. It burns white-hot and releases a fragrant white cloud, the physical picture of the consuming presence of God accepting a sacrifice and wiping away sin.

So look at what John's invented word contains. The *chalkos*, the bronze, is the judged saraph: the metal of the furnace, the place where sin is dealt with by fire, the heavy, unyielding feet of the Judge moving forward to trample the ancient serpent. The *libanos*, the frankincense, is the altar saraph: the white-hot purity of the throne room, the very essence of the burning coal that touched Isaiah's lips and took his guilt away. Just as Moses welded the wound and the cure into a single name in the desert, *nachash nechosheth*, John welds judgment and mercy into a single word. Christ's feet look like bronze that has been completely overtaken by the incandescent, white-hot fire of the altar.

Unlike the fragile clay-and-iron feet of the worldly empires shattered in Daniel's prophecy, this foundation is unyielding. And by echoing the exact "shining bronze" descriptions of Daniel 10 and Ezekiel 1, John is signaling to his readers that the figure standing before him is the very same divine being who visited the ancient prophets by the Tigris and the Chebar.

The Whole Canon Folds Together

Now line it all up, and watch the entire Bible fold in on itself with perfect precision.

In Genesis, the *nachash*, the shining one, uses its radiance to deceive and crush humanity, and God promises that the seed of the woman will crush its head, though the serpent will strike his heel. The feet and the serpent are set against each other on the first pages of the book.

In the wilderness, a dying Israelite looks at a *saraph*, a burning judge, cast in *nechosheth*, the bronze of the furnace, lifted up on wood. He does not merely glance. He steadies his eyes in an expectant, dependent gaze, *nabat*, and he lives.

In Isaiah's throne room, a saraph carries the burning coal of atonement from the altar and takes guilt away.

In Zechariah, God promises the day when Israel will *nabat*, gaze expectantly, on the One they have pierced, and mourn, and be cleansed.

On a hill outside Jerusalem, Jesus is lifted up exactly as the serpent was lifted up, taking the burning venom of the curse into his own body, and every eye that fixes on him in dependent faith lives.

And in Revelation 1, John turns and sees the final, glorified state of the One who was lifted up. Christ did not merely survive the burning fire of judgment. He absorbed it. The bronze of the curse and the white-hot fire of temple atonement have become indistinguishable in him. His feet are *chalkolibanon* because he is the ultimate Saraph, the true Burning One. He is the Judge stepping forward to crush the ancient *nachash* permanently under those feet, and because he took the piercing himself, his burning steps carry the fragrance of total, absolute atonement for anyone who fixes their eyes upon him.

The serpent struck the heel. The heel became burnished bronze, refined in the furnace, and it is coming down on the serpent's head.

Why This Matters

None of this is visible in a quick English reading. "Feet like burnished bronze" sounds like a color, or a texture, and people argue about complexion while the actual glory of the verse sails past them. But the biblical authors chose their words the way a master smith chooses his metal. Serpent and bronze share a root. Burning ones bite in the desert and sing over the throne. An ordinary verb for seeing gives way, at the moment of healing, to a verb of expectant gazing that resurfaces centuries later at the piercing of the Messiah. And a fisherman on a prison island, needing to describe what no language had a word for, forged a new one out of bronze and frankincense, judgment and atonement, and set it at the feet of the risen Christ.

This is not a collection of coincidences. It is a single story, written across fifteen hundred years by dozens of human authors, holding together at the level of individual words. The

wound and the cure are no longer welded into a bronze snake on a pole. They are eternally welded into the resurrection body of Jesus Christ.

Look, and live.